

A POCKETFUL OF DREAMS

KRITI SANON on her latest film *Shehzada*, nine years in Bollywood, and why she wants to experiment with different roles so as to not be put in a box

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Q+A

Q. Was *Mimi* [2021] the game-changer in your career in the way people see and treat you differently now?
Absolutely. People take me a lot more seriously as an actor... Every actor has milestones and *Mimi* was one for me. *Bareilly ki Barfi* was also one, where it was like *'Yeh acting bhi kar sakti hai* [she can act too]' and 'there's more to her than the looks'.

Q. *Shehzada* feels like a safe bet. It is a remake of a hit Telugu film [*Ala Vaikuntha-purramuloo*, 2020], and you work with Kartik Aaryan, with whom you have had a hit already. Was it challenging?
I am a very commercial audience and I like watching films like *Hum Aapke Hain Koun...!*, *Hum Saath Saath Hain*, *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham*, which had a lot of emotion, entertainment, romance and family equation. I don't know why, but somewhere we stopped doing that. *Shehzada* offers all that. Also, I haven't done glamour for a while now...It's not like I want only parts like *Mimi*. I don't want to be put in a box.

Q. With four releases, including *Adipurush*, 2023 seems a pivotal year.
It is my ninth year in the industry and I am a number nine, so I consider it lucky. There is a good mixed bag of releases. I start off in a glam avatar and then go on to play Sita Maa as Janaki [in *Adipurush*]. Then there's *Ganapath*, which is an edgy, *Mad Max*-like action film where I ride a dirt bike and learned to use a weapon. I also start shooting *The Crew* with the amazing Kareena Kapoor Khan and Tabu, actresses whom I admire.

Q. Nine years into the industry, what does Kriti Sanon seek now?
I have better opportunities, so I can choose better. I seek characters that are away from me and go deeper. I would like to produce a film so as to tell stories that I want to tell. I also want to play a grey character and do a superhero film.

with Suhani Singh